

PASSPORT TO PRISON

A widespread human trafficking racket has left Mumbai police desperate for more links and names

■ By Renu Ojha & Aditi Pai

Last November, when Jet Airways grounded 24-year-old air hostess Aliya Rizvi for weighing 2 kg more than the prescribed upper limit of 56 kg, few would have imagined that the price would be so heavy. Unable to handle a cut in her salary—a drop from Rs 1.8 lakh to Rs 40,000 a month—Rizvi decided to take up the offer made by touts Altaf Hassan Shaikh and Yusuf Akram Baig. She was asked to pose as the wife of Ahmedabad-based businessman Rajesh Trivedi to help him get a visa to the US.

With the help of forged documents and a fake marriage affidavit, Trivedi had obtained a passport in the name of Abbas Rizvi. Aliya and Trivedi—with Surat-based passport agent Rajesh Gemlawala in tow—went to the US Consulate for a visa interview. “Aliya stated that she and her husband Abbas wanted to travel to the US for a holiday on a tourist visa,” says investigating officer Ramesh Mahale. Tipped off by an informer, the crime branch had alerted the US Consulate about Aliya’s visit for the interview on November 26. Police Inspector Dattatrey Bhargude and his team arrested them as soon as they walked out. “We have proof against crew members of other airlines as well,” says Mahale.

Cabin crew members are low suspicion carriers since they travel frequently and have permanent jobs. “Investigations have revealed a trend of using airline crew for smuggling people who are not qualified for obtaining visas. Then, fake documents are processed for them in haste. Agents help in completing the immigration formalities. Taking a cue, we are looking at all possible cases,” says Rakesh Maria, joint commissioner of police (crime). Frequent fliers and small businessmen, who travel often and always return to India, are other suspects.

Rizvi’s arrest has exposed a human trafficking chain—comprising travel agents, passport officials, policemen, postal staff and touts—which helps illegal immigrants obtain fake documents and visas. Till date, 23 people have been arrested, including passport officials, post-office clerks and police personnel, apart from touts, agents and travellers. The US Consulate has submitted a list of 72 names of those who travelled to the US over the last two years. The police are hoping it will lead to more names, but



“Human trafficking involves high ranking officials and experts.”

RAKESH MARIA, JOINT COMMISSIONER OF POLICE (CRIME)